

New Cat Owner Checklist

Your first 30 days with a new cat — printable guide

BEFORE YOU BRING YOUR CAT HOME

FOOD & WATER

- ☐ Food bowls (ceramic or stainless steel)
- ☐ Water bowl or fountain
- ☐ Cat food (same brand as shelter/breeder)
- ☐ Healthy treats

COMFORT & SAFETY

- ☐ Covered bed or hiding box
- ☐ Scratching post (vertical + horizontal)
- ☐ Breakaway collar + ID tag
- ☐ Carrier
- ☐ Microchip registered to you

LITTER & CLEANUP

- ☐ Litter box (large, uncovered)
- ☐ Unscented clumping litter
- ☐ Litter scoop
- ☐ Litter mat
- ☐ Enzyme cleaner

PLAY & ENRICHMENT

- ☐ Wand toy
- ☐ Puzzle feeder or treat ball
- ☐ Cat tree or window perch

OPTIONAL

- ☐ Automatic feeder
- ☐ Feliway diffuser
- ☐ Grooming brush & nail trimmers
- ☐ Pet camera

Quick tip: Start with the same food the shelter or previous owner used. Transition to a new brand gradually over 7–10 days to avoid stomach upset.

The 3-3-3 Rule

What to expect in your cat's first 3 months

3 Days — Decompress

Your cat is overwhelmed. Give them a small, quiet safe room and let them hide.

- Keep in one safe room with the door closed
- Let the cat exit the carrier on their own
- No forced interaction or handling
- Same food, fresh water, clean litter

3 Weeks — Settle In

Routine starts to feel familiar. Your cat's real personality begins to emerge.

- Gradual, supervised exploration beyond the safe room
- Establish consistent feeding and play times
- Bond through short play sessions and treats
- Watch appetite, litter habits, and energy

3 Months — Full Trust

The cat treats the home as territory and feels like part of the family.

- Full home access if the cat is confident
- Behavior patterns are stable
- Begin slow introductions to other pets (if any)
- Continue daily play and enrichment

Remember: Every cat is different. Shy or previously traumatized cats may take longer — that's normal, not a sign something is wrong. Let your cat set the pace.

Your First Week: Daily Checklist

Tick off one task each day to build trust the right way

Day	Task	Done
Day 1	Set up safe room; open carrier; let the cat exit on their own	☐
Day 1	Show food, water, and litter box locations gently	☐
Day 1	Keep environment quiet; limit visitors	☐
Day 2	Scoop litter; refresh water	☐
Day 2	Sit quietly in the room for 10 minutes	☐
Day 3	Offer a treat from your hand (do not force)	☐
Day 3	Observe eating, drinking, and litter habits	☐
Day 4	First gentle play session with a wand toy	☐
Day 5	Schedule a wellness vet visit	☐
Day 6	Begin short, supervised exploration outside the safe room	☐
Day 7	Review the week; adjust routine as needed	☐

WHEN TO CALL THE VET IMMEDIATELY

- ☐ Not eating for more than 24 hours
- ☐ No urination in 24 hours, or straining in the litter box
- ☐ Vomiting or diarrhea lasting more than a day
- ☐ Lethargy, weakness, or difficulty breathing
- ☐ Sudden behavior change combined with refusing food

Full guide: Read the complete first-30-days article with shopping links and photos at thecaringpet.com/blog/new-cat-owner-checklist/